Curriculum of the Body: A Foucauldian Analysis of the Physical and Emotional Violence Inflicted on Female Students in Indian Schools

Agreni Batra

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Arts in Curriculum & Teaching in Teachers College, Columbia University

2024

© 2024

Agreni Batra

All Rights Reserved

Abstract

A culture of oppression, and dehumanization that manifests in the form of surveillance of students' bodies prevails in both public and private schools in India (see Lesko, 1988, "Curriculum of the Body"). This culture of dehumanization is perpetrated by teachers, and the larger school ecosystems, which are the product of societal systems. However, teachers are victims of similar surveillance and oppression in their domestic as well as professional lives and as such, become oppressors themselves, and the cycle of violence and dehumanization is reproduced (Freire, 1970).

The purpose of this study was to investigate the culture of surveillance, dehumanization, and oppression in schools in India in order to understand the unique experiences of the students who face it. The insights gleaned from their experiences were used to write recommendations that would help develop curricula, and shape school cultures or policies geared toward humanizing female students in educational institutions, and awakening the critical consciousness for female teachers so that they may better able to reflect on their position both as a perpetrator, perpetuator, and victim of the same violence.

For this study, qualitative data was collected through virtual interviews, using an interview protocol. The sample was comprised of five women between the ages of 26-32 from different cultural, linguistic, and socio-economic backgrounds. Investigating this phenomenon and the extent of its enforcement revealed the systemic patriarchy entrenched within Indian society, bringing to light several issues: gaps in teachers' training curricula, sexist cultures prevailing in schools, the absence of critical conversation around the role of teachers and educational spaces, and the patriarchy that manifests in the form of teachers labeling students, and their own experiences of being labeled. These findings can become starting points for conversations that help redesign school cultures, teacher training curricula, and inform more sensitive and inclusive teaching practices and policies. Overall, the aim is to upend the cycle of dehumanization experienced by both female students and teachers.

Background of the Study

As far as I can remember, I have always been a straight-A student. Growing up, my parents drilled into my head how I needed to be a "good" student. The definition of "good" began with the construction of a child who does well in academics (scores near-perfect grades and marks on tests), abides by their rules, and doesn't question their ideas. My own definition of a "good" student (and I suspect this also means daughter) was influenced by how I was raised and expected to be. For the most part of my school life, I remember being afraid of disappointing my parents, and to let that not happen, I would ensure I was always the straight-A student who did all things "right." What that looked like was getting above 90-95% in all my classes, participating in the "right" kind of extra-curricular activities like quizzes and debates (not dance or theatre), making sure that my school uniform was always "decent" and "tidy," and asking teachers only "smart" questions" so they would perceive me as intelligent. As a result of living like this, I was considered a "model" student (model female student, to be precise): one who never got into trouble, who was gregarious and respectful, who didn't flout any rules, and whom the teachers favored. It came with its benefits; I was made Head Girl, and occupied leadership positions which I used to help my peers, but it also came with the expectation of perfection, obedience, and therefore, submission.

I don't think I ever wanted to be this kind of student. But unfortunately, this was the only way I knew how to be a student. I thought if I had a perfect record, abided by the rules, and would not "get into trouble," I would gain acceptance and praise, and would stave off punishment or a "bad" reputation. In reality, I was afraid of what would happen to me if I did not fulfill these expectations of being the perfect student, because while I was busy "achieving" things, I witnessed my friends (particularly female friends) and peers go through a different, harrowing experience in school. For instance,

- My girlfriends who altered their school uniforms in any way (their skirts shorter than knee length, sleeves, socks, shoes, and hairstyles, different from what was prescribed in the school dress code) faced differing degrees of public warnings and punishments at the beginning of the day in school assemblies. If you consistently faltered in the uniform, you were called names that carried the connotations of promiscuity.
- Girls who had boyfriends or were physically comfortable around boys were especially singled out, shamed, and labeled promiscuous or "loose" and a bad influence on their peers. They bore the consequences: their parents would be called to school often for interventions, they were presumed to be insincere in academics, and they were categorically kept out of opportunities for growth such as extracurricular activities, competitions, debates, and leadership positions in school.
- In some cases, these female students even received antagonistic treatment from teachers. They were gossiped about and used as non-examples in classes. They were perceived as students with a bleak future, and it reflected in the way the teachers (and therefore, the students) spoke about them.

Boys, on the other hand, were somewhat immune to this system. Although they, too, engaged in similar transgressions and got into trouble, the only consequence they bore was being perceived as insincere and "not smart." There were no aspersions cast on their characters or morality; they weren't labeled promiscuous or "loose" to the degree that their female peers were.

I remember feeling abject fear of being shamed. The times I did slip from the path of academic perfection during my adolescence (made new friends of different genders, and explored the concepts of sexuality, relationships, and feelings; scored 84% instead of my usual 95%), I remember my mother reminding me rather harshly of what becomes of "loose" girls in life, and how I was on the path of becoming one myself. Consequently, I guarded myself even more, and became even more strict with myself, how I wanted to be, and how I wanted the world to perceive me. I doubled my self-imposed restrictions, and placed even more structures that made me hyper-vigilant and observant of my actions.

When I began teaching 6th grade in an all-girls public school, I felt liberated for the first time in my life. I could be imperfect in my class. I had about 40 human beings listening to me at all times and experienced a newfound power. As I spent more time in my teaching role, I discovered that teaching is enjoyable not just because you live the possibility of changing lives by helping students in multiple aspects, but more so because it brought me a sense of power. However, for someone not as aware of their traumas as I was, I knew this could be a dangerous slippery slope where one could easily project those traumas onto one's students, and misuse the power to feel better about oneself. I will not lie; I enjoyed feeling powerful and heard in my class. But I kept myself in check; I put structures in place that enabled my students and my co-fellows to keep me in check as well. Whenever I felt that the power was getting into my head, I would ask myself, "Agreni, you have power in this space. What do you want to do with it?" This reflective questioning helped me find my purpose in teaching.

This all-girls public school that I taught in catered to lower-income, lower-caste, and migrant communities. As a result, the degree of strictness concerning rules, dress codes, morality, and "good" behavior was far more brutal than I had witnessed in my own elite private high school. The students faced severe punishment (oftentimes, corporal punishment), and public humiliation in school assemblies for not following the dress code. In an incident that chills me to this day, a student was being hounded at the school gate at 8:00 am for wearing a differently colored ribbon in her hair. The dress code demanded white, but she was wearing a red ribbon. Something as insignificant as a differently colored ribbon in her hair resulted in her having to run rounds of the school playground for a whole hour.

In general, it seemed that teachers regarded all the students in this school as somewhat promiscuous. I believe it had to do with the fact that they belonged to lower socioeconomic and caste groups. Those students who escaped the character assassination were overachievers; they were the girls who made it "despite their unfortunate circumstances and bad influences around them." But the threshold for being labeled promiscuous, or being sexualized was very low for those who did not or were unable to rise to the academic expectations, and/ or the rules of propriety placed on the female students. If they were found experimenting with their looks, modifying their uniforms, wearing makeup, and styling their hair, it was almost impossible to escape character assassination. These same students were humiliated and labeled for non-obedience of rules, and for being vocal about their resentment. They were also labeled if they were found to be loitering outside of school spaces, engaging in self-expression like making TikToks, or clicking selfies. Conversations about sex were extremely taboo—there was no formal

sexual health curriculum in the school. The only conversations that happened were around the biological process of menstruation. Another significant aspect of this school was a culture that discouraged its female students from being ambitious. Pure sciences and STEM subjects were unavailable for all students; the only options were arts, humanities, and home sciences-traditionally regarded as more "feminine" subjects—the subjects the school management thought the students could supposedly handle (McCall, 2014).

In light of this dehumanizing school culture, and my own experiences of transgressing policing and labeling, teaching my 41 girls made me feel liberated. It allowed me to legitimately transgress the same rules and policing that I had abided by when I was a student. As a teacher, it was important for me to hold space for them; I assured them that they looked great and they could dress however they wanted to, I talked about sex, consent, relationships, and feelings in my classroom, I pushed them to expect more of themselves, to speak up on matters that concerned their identities and lives. Doing this was true liberation- it felt like a consolation for my younger self, and purpose for my adult self. Through these spaces, my students began to realize how they were being oppressed by the systems around them, gradually pushing back on elements of these systems like their families, their public-spaces, and the rules that were placed on them by the school.

Developing A Critical Consciousness

My teaching helped me build just as much critical consciousness as it did my students. Even as my pedagogy intervened in a manner that enabled my students to question the different degrees of their oppression, and act on it, I simultaneously questioned why schools were designed in such a manner. Why did the teachers inflict violence in these forms of physical and emotional abuse, surveillance, and control? Save for one or two teachers, nobody really intervened in this system of physical and emotional violence. Were the teachers doing this because they were evil? How could the teachers not see how disempowering, and dehumanizing such a treatment of children was? How could they not understand that such treatment of students is contradictory to the meaning of education—of fostering critical thought, developing new ideas that liberate peoples (Biesta, 2014). It was so easy (for myself, as well) to demonize the teachers and the system when I witnessed the violence. The evident class difference, and the resulting difference in privilege between me and the teachers made the demonizing easier. But after a year of demonizing them, I realized that just as I did with my students, I must go deeper into the teachers' lives and contexts too, in order to understand how this dehumanizing pedagogy continued to be wielded. As I spent time building relationships with the teachers, understanding their contexts, their families, their personal and professional challenges, and their humanity, I could see how their pedagogy was, in fact, informed by complex trauma, surveillance, and a lack of autonomy that they had grown up in, and were continuing to experience in their lives:

- They were born and married into patriarchal families. They had little autonomy over decisions, finances, and the expectations within their families. They were victims of patriarchy themselves.
- Their socioeconomic conditions exacerbated their lack of control over and expectations of labor in their families
- They likely experienced the same kind of surveillance, character assassination, violence, and lack of self-expression that they inflicted on their students.

- They were in the profession of teaching because it was the only profession deemed 'appropriate' by their families, and therefore, they worked as teachers out of a necessity, not out of passion.

These observations and realizations then started to make sense; the teachers, who belonged to upper caste, middle class households, lived tremendously regimented lives consisting of domestic labor, family responsibilities, and a lack of voice, which formed the tenets of their lives marked by patriarchy. With such a lack of autonomy, the classroom automatically became a space where they could exert power and influence which they otherwise lacked in their lives. They perpetuated the same dictates of propriety that they grew up with, and used the same mechanisms of humiliation, physical and emotional violence that they grew up with, and that molded them into the women they were in present times who did everything right. Their students internalized these regimes of oppression, and together, the teachers and students formed the cycle of oppression and violence that continued to dehumanize the female student and human.

Problem Statement

A culture of oppression, and dehumanization that manifests in the form of surveillance of students' bodies prevails in both public and private schools in India. Students, particularly female students, routinely experience policing, and character assassination for any and every aspect of their individuality, including their appearances, clothing, manner of talking, or social relationships. They are either categorized into the overachieving, 'revered' students, or the promiscuous, 'loose' students with bleak futures. In this process of labeling, the students experience physical and emotional violence from the teachers, and are therefore dehumanized.

This culture of dehumanization is perpetrated and perpetuated by teachers, and the larger school ecosystems, which are the product of societal systems. Teachers are victims of similar surveillance and oppression in their domestic as well as professional lives. Their past educational experiences as well as workplaces subject them to similar labeling. The patriarchal and binary-gender norms that dictate their lives deprive them of identity and power over their own lives, decision-making, and actions. As a result, these oppressed women become oppressors themselves, and the cycle of violence and dehumanization is reproduced (Freire, 1970).

Purpose of the Study

Therefore, the purpose of this study was to investigate, and document the culture of surveillance, dehumanization, and oppression in schools for female students in India, and use the findings to synthesize the reality of Curriculum of the Body as an issue in schools, so that this formative study can become part of a bigger, and more extensive project that addresses these problems systematically.

Research Questions

The following research questions guide my study:

1. What are the factors underscoring a culture of surveillance, control, and violence in public and private schools in India?

2. In what ways is this culture of violence and surveillance perpetuated by female teachers, especially in same-gender public schools in India?
3. What is the impact of the culture of violence and surveillance on female students, and how do their authentic experiences inform our understanding of the issue?

Significance of the Study

My study is significant for several reasons. Curriculum of the Body (Lesko, 1988, p. 123), and the dehumanization of female students is institutionalized in Indian schools, whether public or private. These systems are pervasive; they exist as implicit bodies of knowledge that play a significant role in determining school cultures, teacher attitudes, and reinforcing gendered expectations of behavior. Every female student is a victim of this implicit curriculum, as it produces unique experiences for her that determine her self-images, identities, and success in schools. However, despite coloring the female students' experiences in such an influential manner, its presence within schools and institutions is not formally acknowledged or theorized. The connection between Curriculum of the Body, and how it is perpetuated by its own victims–the teachers, is also a significant aspect delineated in my study, and which deserves wider recognition and documentation. Furthermore, this concept has scope for detailed examination, as it is complicated by multiple intersecting identities of gender, caste, class, an urban-rural divide, etc., which can be taken up by scholars in the future.

Review of Literature

In the following section, I address several areas that inform and guide my study. I begin by explaining the concept of Curriculum of the Body, and how it manifests itself in schools. I then highlight how it transpires differently in Indian schools, influenced by different socio-cultural and economic factors, detailing several relevant examples of Curriculum of the Body, in non-educational settings as well. I then analyze my study through a Foucauldian lens, specifically drawing on examples of my experiences of teaching in an all-girls public school. I also highlight how this curriculum plays out uniquely in single-gender schools, and becomes a tool of reinforcing heteronormativity. I then detail a section on the teacher, historicizing the female teacher, her position and oppression which makes her perpetuate a cycle of dehumanization. Ultimately, I detail the ideas of several authors that helped me conceptualize recommendations that can help build critical consciousness among teachers, and improve school cultures in a way that humanize the female students.

Curriculum of the Body in Indian Schools and Society

Lesko (1988) defines "Curriculum of the Body" as the "total set of intended and unintended school experiences involving knowledge of the body and sensuality" that are "central" to the perpetuation of gender identities (p. 123). According to Lesko (1988), "language use, dress, make-up, hairstyles, and use of leisure time ranked girls as lower or higher status," and assigned them to categories corresponding to their status. Essentially, the school in her study institutionalized 'norms' regarding "proper sexual and bodily expression that operated as a classifying system for high school girls" (p. 124). Female students who adhered to the dress code of the school and followed "traditional feminine dictates of modesty, youthfulness, and niceness"

were defined as appropriate, and labeled "rich and popular" (p. 131). Those who transgressed the expectations of niceness, modesty, and negotiation were labeled "loose." A third category of female student—the outcast—did not fit into either category; she had good grades, but openly critiqued the school and teachers. Her behavior was "out of place," the toll of which would be exacted on her in the form of keeping her out of opportunities for growth and self-identification (p. 138). This implicit Curriculum of the Body

> suggests the possibility that for young women, school status and opportunities are not the result of what just they know or do in academics or extracurriculars, but that their position in a school organization and among peers is strongly influenced by how they control, or fail to control their bodies (Lesko, 1988, p. 139).

In Indian public and private schools, a similar Curriculum of the Body is institutionalized within school cultures. However, the female students' performance of gender, their transgressions, and therefore, the categories and labels assigned to them, vary according to their context, socioeconomic status, and caste identities. The categories delineated by Lesko (1980) are not found in an exact replication in these schools; however, the principle of surveillance and labeling of female students to produce desired gender behavior stands in both contexts. The categories might be different, but the phenomenon of 'categorization' is present in both types of schools and contexts, for the purpose of punishing the transgression by female students of established rules of body and conduct. Both result in a control of female bodies, the stripping of humanity of the students by reducing them either to a utopian idea of a submissive student, or sexualizing any kind of transgression from the established norms of gender performance.

Piyali Sur (2021) elucidates the regimes of surveillance, and the phenomenon of categorization in her study on discipline and surveillance in a reputed English-medium school in Kolkata, India. By interviewing 25 adolescent girls aged 15-19, she notes how "girls are aware that they are subject to sexist social and cultural values, that their bodies are linked to morality and that there is objectification of their bodies" (p. 1). She explains several phenomena constituting the implicit Curriculum of the Body that play out within the school, through which "physical bodies are subjugated through disciplinary power, and subjects learn to constrain themselves and behave in expected ways" (p. 6). These include "rules and regulations regarding school uniforms" that "attempt to prohibit bodies from drawing attention to themselves, desexualizes them, and disciplines them" (p. 7). These also include regulations on physical intimacy "to stem inappropriate or unwanted touching" (Allen, 2009), enforced by teachers going on walks during recess to ensure no students occupy the empty classrooms lest they indulge in physical intimacy, teachers "raiding" (p. 8) spaces in schools designated by students as the "loving place," and teachers surveilling public spaces in the school like corridors for evidence of "touching" (p. 8) between girls and boys. They also comprise labeling and character assassination for indulging in activities such as "folding-up of skirts" (p. 9), dating and having boyfriends, being physically comfortable and friendly with boys, and various small and big actions that constitute the transgression of established norms within the school. This policing is done to render bodies docile, "to the extent that they disappear" (Paechter, 2010, p. 314). Such a curriculum "intensifies the oppositions between different constructions of femininity and cement them more firmly as fundamental elements of girls' social and personal identities, thereby making female solidarity an elusive goal" (Lesko, 1988). In other words, the labeling of female

students as moral or immoral by the institutionalized practices of the Curriculum of the Body also becomes a discriminatory practice within themselves, and thus they are prevented from uniting and calling out problematic systems that dehumanize them.

Such practices are also seen in higher education in India. "College and university campuses and hostels for women students in higher education institutions subject women to discriminatory restrictions and intrusive surveillance on the pretext of safety from sexual violence" (Krishnan, 2018, p. 76). According to Krishnan (2018), even adult women are subjected to humiliating processes of moral policing by their institutions and hostel administrations in which they are interrogated and/or shamed about their movement, choices, activities, clothes, and actions, thereby controlling their opportunities of growth and learning. Interestingly, a similar practice of surveillance and gendered punishment was observed in textile factories in the state of Tamil Nadu, in India. In a study called Flawed Fabrics (Theuws and Overeem, 2014), it was found that "in the case of large female workforces, management invokes patriarchal notions of 'culture' and morality, alongside methods of public shaming and sexualised abuse, to restrict women workers' mobility and access to means of communication, thus deterring and preventing workers from unionising" (Krishnan, 2018, p. 80). In some instances, male supervisors including managers call the women by abusive names, and cast aspersions on their character. Such "scolding" includes asking women if they spent the night on the street, suggesting that the women are sex-workers and therefore immoral, and asking the woman if she "ate food or shit," which has "casteist connotations to it because the lower-cast (Dalit) workers in the country are unfortunately relegated to professions that include cleaning human excreta" (Krishnan, 2018, p. 81). The study concludes how this system of punishment helps "fashion a more disciplined and cheaper workforce of women" (Theuws and Overeem, 2014; PUCL et al., 2016 as cited in Krishnan, 2018, p. 82). By subjecting women workers to forms of punishment that cast aspersions on their sexual morality, women are forced to "prove their own respectability by their willing submission to the regimes of surveillance and restrictions on mobility and communication" (Krishnan, 2018, p. 82). Additionally, by preventing interaction with male workers or outside activists, and socialization amongst one another, women workers are prevented from "even visualizing the possibility of unionizing" (Krishnan, 2018, p. 82).

Theoretical Lens

In this section, I analyze the Curriculum of the body by specifically focusing on how it played out in the low-income public girls' school in which I taught. I begin my theoretical analysis from a Foucauldian lens, starting with defining the process of 'normalization' (Foucault, 1979). I detail various norms at play in the school, and discuss how they constitute ideas of 'Brahmanical femininity' (Chakravarti, 1993). I further discuss the regimes of discipline and surveillance at play that enforce the norms of Brahmanical femininity in schools. I conclude by discussing how the aforementioned regimes form mechanisms of biopower that are embedded within school cultures, and are meant to control student bodies to generate 'compliance' with status quo (Foucault, 1976).

Processes of Normalization

Normalization is the establishment of which behaviors, actions, or practices are acceptable, and which ones are not. These established "norms" then dictate desirable actions out of the subjects upon which they are enforced. In the different contexts described above, the norms dictated specific performances of femininity and gender, that were institutionalized. In the public school I taught in, the performances of femininity and gender comprised the following norms.

Norms of Appearance

The female students are expected to abide by a strict dress code that lays down the exact length, colors, and way of donning their uniforms, which is a salwar-kameez (traditional north-Indian feminine attire). The dress code promotes "modesty" by means of its design, and covers most of the students' bodies except their wrists, hands, neck, and face. The hair is to be braided with white ribbons; makeup and jewelry are strictly prohibited, and the uniform is expected to be clean and tidy at all times.

Norms of Behavior and Conduct

The female students are expected to be obedient at all times. They have to obey the class and school rules, obey their teachers and parents, as well as any implicit expectations of propriety. They are expected to display "respect" and acceptance of authority. They also have to conduct themselves "decently"—in no way can their behavior reflect a sexual desire, or they would be labeled promiscuous, or "loose." They are strictly prohibited from engaging with people of other genders (specifically straight male students), having boyfriends, or being in any type of romantic relationship.

Norms of academic performance

The students are expected to perform at the top of their class; have their work done the "correct" way, participate in classroom discussions and speak the "right" answers, participate in extracurricular activities, and possess the communication and negotiation skills which demonstrate "intelligence" and respect.

Norms of mobility

The students cannot move about the school premises of their own free will. They have to take permission before leaving class, and are disallowed from being in the corridors during class time. At the end of the school day, they are ushered out of the school at exactly 12:30 pm, because the school building is also used for a second shift of the school day, which was a boys' school; essentially, the school administration intends to prohibit interactions between the girls and the boys. The students are also expected to go straight home after school, and not "linger" or "loiter" on the streets, or the public spaces outside school. If found loitering, they are reprimanded by the teachers the next morning.

Norms of self-expression

Students are discouraged from, and judged for being on social media, clicking pictures, making TikTok or dance videos. Even though they are not outrightly prohibited from it, indulging in these activities carries with it a connotation of being "improper" or "morally loose."

The purpose of these norms of gender and femininity is to dictate what actions are acceptable and what are deviant in the school. The performance of, or adherence to the norms constitutes the "ideal" or the "perfect" female student, and brings the female students' acceptance, even praise. However, the non-performance of these norms invites discipline and punishment (Foucault, 1979), and the forms they take are gendered (Krishnan, 2018). The normalization of these sets of actions influences the female students' self-perception, social interactions, and educational experiences (Lesko, 1988).

It is imperative to note here that the particular norms of femininity discussed above exemplifies Brahmanical, or upper-caste femininity, which dictates women to be domesticated and pious, and views women's sexuality, as well as autonomy as a threat (Chakravarti, 1993). When notions of patriarchy and caste intersect, they create a complex system of social stratification where gender roles and power dynamics are deeply intertwined with caste identities and hierarchies (Chakravarti, 1993). Since Indian society operates within the framework of caste hierarchy, the norms of gender performance reinforced in schools become 'Brahmanised' (Arya, 2020). As a result, the expectations of 'correct' gender performance in schools and institutions reflect the Brahmanical ideas of modesty, chastity, submission, limitations on mobility, and silencing of voice (Arya, 2020).

These norms of femininity and "appropriate" gender performance are enforced in the school by regimes of "hierarchized surveillance" (Foucault, 1979, p. 191) that help serialize, individualize, and ultimately, control the bodies (Macey & Foucault, 2003). These surveillance mechanisms are multi-faceted, and embedded within the school culture as continuous, functional systems (Foucault, 1979, p. 191). Students' actions, clothes, and behavior are observed at all times within and outside classrooms by authority figures such as teachers, school administration, or the principal. The design of the school building comprises long corridors, classrooms adjacent to one another, and open quadrangles with the senior faculty and the principal's offices on the ground floor, which enable "visibility" (p.191) of student movement at all times. The school has morning assemblies, in which students stand in ordered queues on the ground while the principal and senior teachers stand on a slightly raised platform (Foucault, 1979) that allows them to observe the students' bodies for compliance or non-compliance of the norms. Some of the "best pupils" (p. 190)—those students who always follow the norms—are selected as uniform monitors and prefects, who help enforce the rules of uniform and proper behavior by surveilling their peers and reporting non-conformity to the teachers and school authorities. As a result of these regimes of surveillance, students internalize a fear of being watched, and often call out each other's behaviors or non-conformity to rules within peer groups, thus fulfilling the purpose of the 'panopticon' of power (Foucault, 1977).

The failure to perform the norms of "proper" feminine behavior invites punishment. Essentially, if the students transgress, or refuse to follow the dress code by modifying their uniforms, wearing makeup or different hairstyles, engage in sexual or romantic relationships, interact with boys, speak "loudly" to argue with their teachers to make themselves heard (Lesko, 1988), fail their standardized tests, or were found on the streets, they are labeled "loose," and "promiscuous." At the same time, students who abide by the norms are idolized. The consequences of non-adherence to the norms are sexualization, character assassination, and demonization. Thus, the mechanism of punishment creates different categories of female students (Lesko, 1988). The "loose" students experience public humiliation over their deviant behaviors,

are excluded from opportunities for growth such as extracurricular activities, and fear being negatively marked on their report cards, while the "perfect" students are lauded for their "excellence." The punishment for deviance, thus, produces altered gender behavior among the female students. Together with the regimes of surveillance, these forms of punishment contribute to the larger "operation of disciplinary power" (Foucault, 1979, p. 191) within the school that subjugates and dehumanizes all the female students. The discipline and punishment enforced together also result in the creation of social hierarchies—by labeling female students as "perfect," "pure," "loose" or "immoral," a divide is created among them as a community. The "perfect" students usually eat, work, and socialize together in groups, being careful not to associate with the "loose" students, lest they be categorized with them. In this manner, the norm-abiding students prove their respectability and worth by maintaining a distance from the other, "deviant" category of students (Krishnan, 2018). This is an exemplification of what Ball (1990) describes as the "dividing practices" (p. 4) that are "achieved within the subject," (p. 4), and which regulate and control individuals.

In the phenomenon described above, the normalization of appropriate feminine behaviors in public girls schools, and the regimes of surveillance and punishment to enforce those norms constitute forces of biopower that control female student bodies (Macey & Foucault, 2003). Rules of uniform, mobility, conversation, and relationships directly influence the way female students see themselves, and construct their ideas of femininity (Lesko, 1988). These regimes also regulate, and produce knowledges and discourses of gender roles, relationships, appearance, and appropriate feminine behavior, which are disseminated and further exert power over female subjectivities (Ball, 1990).

Negotiating Norms of Behavior for Self-Expression

Curriculum of the Body, whether in schools, or in workplaces, aims to control female bodies to produce a specific performance of gender and femininity out of them (Lesko, 1988). There are also instances where the female student or worker negotiates aspects of this code of femininity for self-expression. As explained by Sur (2021),

> Within this disempowering environment of educational imperative and external control, student sexual cultures become imbued with significance as adult-free and education-free zones where students collectively negotiate what is acceptable/desirable and what is 'too much' (2004: 214) (p. 13).

Essentially, female students determine and negotiate forms of self and sexual-expression in order to assert themselves and create a sense of autonomy within their own peer-groups as a way to navigate an otherwise highly controlled environment.

Another way that female students negotiate self-expression is by (over)compensating for the transgression of a particular norm of behavior, appearance, or sexual conduct through consistently displaying adherence and excellence toward other norms, particularly those relating to academic performance. For instance, some female students will ensure consistently excellent performance in grades, participation in co-curricular activities, and maintaining positive relations with their teachers in the hope that it builds enough credit for them to escape punishment for the non-adherence to some other norms, or lessens the severity of the punishment. Students also engage in such negotiation to express queerness. Nevatia, Raj, Mahajan, Shah, Lesbians and

Bisexuals in Action (LABIA) (2021) highlight this phenomenon through Anand's story, who was assigned female at birth, but later came to identify as queer. They wanted to keep their hair short, and wear trousers and a shirt instead of a skirt and blouse. Initially met with brutal resistance upon transgressing the uniform rules, the school authorities conceded with them over time. This was made possible because Anand used their credentials–good grades, dedicated sincerity, and presence in the classroom–as a bargaining chip to negotiate their expression of gender non-conformity and queerness in the school (p. 58).

Reinforcing Heteronormativity

It is important to understand how Curriculum of the Body plays out in single-gender schools. McCall (2014) explains how despite their intended purposes of providing female students access to an equitable, and possibly superior education, and equipping them to surmount gender discrimination and stratification, single-gender schools regulate female sexuality and desire through the discourses of protection, and the emphasis on minimizing sexual tension and distractions between girls and boys. She further explains how the prevailing discourses of gender-segregated schooling perpetuate the idea that girls should fear themselves as sexual agents, and should be protected from their desires. The regulation of sexuality and desire in these schools teaches particular norms and expectations of femininity, ultimately contributing to the maintenance of heteronormativity. Therefore, through the regulation of sexuality and desire, single-gender schools become particular sites of the curriculum of the body, and reinforce discourses of protection and the enforcement of traditional gender roles and expectations.

Sur (2021) explains that in mixed-gender schools, heteronormativity is reinforced when female students' self-image is influenced by how male students perceive them, such as label them as "wife material" (p. 9) or not, depending on how "promiscuous" the girls are. They also label girls on how conventionally attractive they are (p. 9). This substantiates that "girls do not subvert normative codes of femininity, but collude with their male partners to produce male power. In this manner, gender hierarchy continues to organize adolescent heterosexual relationships (p. 10). Therefore, both single-gender and mixed-gender schools reinforce heteronormativity and specific performances of femininity from girls.

Krishna Kumar, in his chapter 'Growing Up Male' in Gender and Education in India (2021), resonates with the aforementioned ideas. He offers accounts from his boyhood that highlight how the separation of girls and boys in two different schools led to the boys' "dehumanization," and "objectification" of the girls (p. 37). He describes how the physical space that was the girls' school "was enclosed by a ring of classrooms" (p. 36), high trees, accessible through a "twenty-foot high iron gate that opened only twice a day" (p. 36). On the contrary, the boys' school was "a big space attached to the school, devoid of any symbolism of confinement" (p. 37). Additionally, this culture of the dehumanization of girls is "characterized by total silence on sexual behavior and by subtle promotion of the ideal of celibacy as a qualification of sainthood" in female as well as male characters in textbooks (p. 38). Kumar further expresses how the separation of girls and boys resulted in minimal meaningful contact between the two genders, while on the other hand, he would encounter hundreds of girls in everyday life (p. 38). Coupled with conventional discourses on girls being "temporary property," or "references to women as a problem among women themselves" (p. 38), these phenomena reinforced ideas of objectification and dehumanization of women and girls, while normalizing heteronormative structures.

Yet another example of normalized 'appropriate' feminine behavior that reinforces heteronormativity within school cultures is the responsibility placed on the female students in a classroom to restore the moral equilibrium during and after a class breakdown. Typically, in the setup of a mixed-gender classroom, the male students are allowed the liberty of making trouble , disrupting the class, and oftentimes, upsetting the teacher, more so when it is a female teacher. In these cases, the female students of the class perform the act of comforting the upset teacher, negotiate the restoration of "peace" in the class, and upholding morality and discipline within the class (Geetha, 2009). This is another form of the femininity that is idolized and expected to be performed by the female students. This becomes the "correct" way to act for the female students, and they become the de-facto upholders of morality in classrooms while boys are allowed to 'mess up.' In this manner, heteronormative ideas are reinforced.

The Teacher

In this section, I address the teacher, specifically the female teacher, as one of the key enforcers of the Curriculum of the Body in schools, and thus, important to understanding how the curriculum perpetuates and creates violence for female students. As mentioned by Sur (2021), "surveillance by teachers is constant" (p. 13). Teachers carry out the routine tasks of surveillance such as checking uniforms, chaperoning and supervising students' actions and behaviors, and enforcing disciplinary action that includes commenting, scolding, character assassination, and in some cases, body shaming.

However, this teacher is also oppressed within her own upper-caste household. Internal and external pressures that shape gender dynamics within upper-caste/class families constrain women's autonomy and agency within the household, often leading to a sense of powerlessness. This lack of autonomy is influenced by social, cultural, and familial expectations, which limit women's ability to make independent decisions about their lives (Chakravarti, 2021). Patriarchal norms and practices within the family perpetuate gender inequalities and limit women's autonomy (Chakravarti, 2021). Women also engage in significant denial, whether it is related to food, leisure, health, or sexual desires. This denial is a result of societal expectations, compelling them to prioritize roles as wives, sisters, daughters, and mothers, often sacrificing their own needs for those of their husbands (Geetha, 2021). However, in the transition from a feudal to a capitalist (from caste to class-based) economy in India, there is an emergence of new patriarchal ideologies that rationalize the evolving economic landscape, impacting the labor dynamics for both men and women, especially in urban middle and working classes. With increasing numbers of women entering the workforce to support themselves and their families, the control over women has transformed from overt exclusion from education and work to control over access to education and work (Maria Mies, 1979; Liddle and Joshi, 1986 as cited by Ray, 2021, p. 221). Thus, most women are confined to traditionally "feminine" jobs, such as teaching. It is a profession that guarantees women a stable job and income and short working hours that enable them to devote the rest of their day to the household chores associated with traditional gender roles such as cooking, cleaning, and looking after their families. Traditional, patriarchal Indian families also deem teaching as the only "appropriate" profession for women because it allows them to practice motherhood in the form of looking after children. Therefore, it is highly likely that teachers, especially those from strictly patriarchal families, are in the profession not out of a

willingness and passion to be reflective, change-making educators, but because it guarantees them the opportunity to have a livelihood in their otherwise highly controlled lives.

The classroom–a space to exercise power

To make up for the relative lack of power they have over their own lives, teachers have their classroom space, over which they might choose to exercise power. Paik (2021) in her study of the different forms of discipline and control at work in schools and homes notes how she observed some teachers enjoying their position and power, and doing everything possible to maintain their exalted position, especially in a classroom of Dalit and lower class students. According to Paik,

> the teachers refused to befriend the students and made every effort to present the image of a strict disciplinarian. They thought that, like the elders in a family, it was important to be aloof to command respect. Those who gathered enough courage to ask a question were reprimanded ferociously, being shouted at and insulted. The very demeanor of some Brahman and upper-caste teachers silenced the pupils (p. 254)

It may also be the case that institutional expectations may emphasize maintaining control and order within the classroom. This can lead to the use of disciplinary measures that disproportionately affect marginalized students, as teachers seek to conform to institutional expectations regarding behavior and discipline. Thus, teachers might be aware of the power and violence they are inflicting, and continue to do so in order to fulfill institutional expectations (Paik, 2021).

Such exercising of power by teachers over female student bodies perpetuates a cycle of dehumanization (Freire, 1970). The teachers, oppressed throughout their lives by patriarchal family and societal structures, inflict similar oppression on their students by enforcing the Curriculum of the Body. So deep is the internalization of this violence, that the teachers justify the oppressive structures that dehumanize the female students by claiming that such treatment is what they experienced as students themselves, and that it is necessary to "discipline" the students for their own good. The oppressed teacher thus becomes the oppressor of the female students (Freire, 1970).

Methodology

This study is qualitative in nature. To conduct this study, I first prepared an interview protocol consisting of 13 questions. Next, I used the guide to interview five Indian women between the ages of 26 and 33 who completed their high school education and grew up in India. Each interview was about 90 minutes long and was conducted on Zoom. The participants used a mixture of Hindi and English in the interviews. I piloted the interview guide with the first interviewee, and consequently, reworked the interview guide by rearranging the interview questions into three distinct sections that did not exist before. This made the responses generated in the consecutive interviews more ordered and allowed for a natural progression in responses. I gathered and sorted the qualitative data collected from the interviews in the form of video recordings, Zoom-generated transcripts of the interviews, and hand-written notes. I created an

Excel spreadsheet where I made digital notes of each interviewee's responses to each question in the interview guide. Next, I coded the qualitative data through a mixed approach comprising deductive and inductive coding (Saldaña, 2009). I created 17 a-priori codes using my research questions, and review of literature. As I watched the recorded interview videos and went through the transcripts and my hand-written notes, I added additional, new codes for the information that did not fall under the a-priori codes. Once I had an exhaustive list of codes, I grouped them into five categories using Microsoft Excel and color-coding. These categories corresponded to the questions from the interview guide. Then I analyzed my qualitative data using these five categories. Finally, I presented the findings from the interviews conducted with the help of the categories.

Findings

The findings of the qualitative interviews conducted with each participant bore similarities, and yet, were emblematic of the complex socio-economic differences that made up their individual lives. In order to maintain anonymity, I used pseudonyms for my participants. The following were the findings of my qualitative analysis:

1. Curriculum of the Body was ubiquitous in every participant's school

   Rules of uniform, norms of proper behavior, and code of conduct existed in all the participants' schools. They were enforced through systems of surveillance and punishment. In all the participants' schools, the female students were repeatedly reminded of the rules of uniform. The uniform was oftentimes uncomfortable especially in the summer months. For instance, Megha notes that the girls in her school were required to wear ties, even in the hot summer months, and the teachers particularly emphasized the need for ties as a requirement for a 'decent' look, indicating a coverage for the girls' developing breasts. The students noted feeling surveilled through school assemblies, being called out in public spaces, repeated uniform checking, and within classes. Punishment consisted of both physical and emotional violence. Examples of physical violence included making the entire class stand with raised hands as mentioned by Amita, physically hitting the female students, attempting to fix the students' skirts, hair, and uniforms. Emotional violence consisted of assigning demeaning labels to the female students, that carried connotations of being promiscuous, or in some cases, unattractive. Himani notes how her school principal would call her and her friends '*amma,*' or matronly and unattractive, because the length of her skirt was 'too long.' The labels were reinforced through comments and taunts in the classroom by teachers, which would eventually be internalized by the students themselves, and use those words and phrases for one another, thus continuing the cycle of violence (Freire, 1970). However, the punishment was not always overt; in some cases, normalization was achieved by reinforcing certain actions. For instance, Himani mentions that in her school, following the rules in female students was consistently rewarded through prefectorial positions, award and accolades, and public recognition for being a 'good' student.

   The participants also noted being policed for occupying public spaces. Amita shared how one time in 7th grade, she was roaming the grounds of her school with a classmate because she wanted to explore an alley behind one of her school buildings. She emphasized how her roaming was nothing more than a childlike curiosity, and penchant

for fun. She was caught by her school principal, and as a consequence her parents were called for her ‘unruly’ behavior. Yogita also notes how walking in the corridors of her school, especially with a male classmate made her feel more uncomfortable and surveilled, especially after her experience of being hounded for being found in the corridor with a male classmate whom the teachers understood to be her boyfriend.

Romantic relationships were highly stigmatized in all the participants’ schools, because it was assumed that in the mixed gender schools, girls and boys together made for a “de facto sexual environment” (McCall, 2014, p. 7). They noted feeling ‘watched’ when they would interact openly and more frequently than usual with their male friends. Even in Amita’s all girls school, if it was found that a student had a boyfriend, or was in an intimate relationship with someone who was perceived male, she would be called ‘characterless.’

2. Purity of character was especially tied to academic performance

The label ‘academically poor’ or ‘insincere in studies’ was common to the transgressive female students in all the participants’ schools. In Indian culture, having a ‘good’ academic record connotes good character in a female student. The converse is also true; to have a bad academic record invites questions about character and morality. For some participants, the transgression of norms of feminine behavior carried the label of being insincere or disinterested in studies, because to be disinterested in studies means to be of loose character. Amita’s experience of playing with chalk in her 7th grade class exemplified this analysis. She recalled that as 12-year old child it was something that seemed fun to her and her classmates that quickly became chaotic in her class as they all started messing around with chalk upon seeing her do it. The teacher who stopped the chaos took Amita out of the classroom and “interrogated” her entire academic record; including her grades across different subjects, the grades in her previous classes, and also questioned her life goals, iterating how she would never be able to meet those goals if she kept playing around in school. Amita said that it felt too harsh to question her on her grades and academic goals just because she was found to be playing with some chalk. Her teacher weaponized the expectation of ‘good’ academic performance to dictate ‘proper’ and ‘appropriate’ behavior to Amita. Megha noted how the expectation to be academically strong disadvantaged her as a female student with undiagnosed ADHD in a school hyperfocused on academic excellence. She explained how she was put in a grade level higher for her cognitive development and age, and as a result, she could not keep up with the classwork and homework assignments, and was constantly scrutinized for her work. Her inability to perform in academics earned her the labels ‘not smart’ and ‘insincere,’ and thus, also called her character into question. This was further complicated by her tendency to speak up and call out her teachers’ unfair labeling of her abilities, which confirmed the teachers’ beliefs of Megha being of questionable character. Essentially, students were not called "loose" directly, they were called "poor in academics" or "disinterested", and that constructed and coloured the narratives about the abilities of the female students. The need to be academically strong was paramount.

3. Perception of female students before and after puberty

   As soon as the girls hit puberty, the surveillance and sexualization they experienced increased and became more violent, as noted by all participants. All of them shared how messages on decent uniforms were made more frequent, and were more violently enforced after puberty. One specific example of this is that when they attained puberty, all the participants were told repeatedly to wear a white chemise over their bras in order to hide visible bra outlines and the silhouettes of their developing bodies. Himani mentioned how at her co-ed international school, the students, especially female students from elementary grades, were labeled *'junglee,'* or wild, owing to their tendency to display the carefree and outspoken attitude possessed by children who have not yet internalized a sexualizing surveillance. This kind of labeling of elementary grade students was widely normalized in her school. However, as the female students transitioned into middle and high school, they were relinquished from the 'wild' label, as they "became more proper and well-mannered." Essentially, the female students, having attained puberty, were surveilled into following the norms dictating appropriate feminine behaviors, and thus were bestowed with the more positive labels of 'proper' and 'well-mannered' (Sur, 2021).

4. Differential punishment due to students' caste and class status

   The schools where the participants studied catered to middle class, and upper-middle class families. All the participants in my study claimed to belong to the 'upper' castes, which influenced the kind of messages they were given about their bodies and the corresponding expectations of femininity they were to uphold. Essentially, the standards of femininity they were supposed to uphold were the tenets of Brahmanical femininity, that prescribes a cis-female to be docile, subservient, and chaste (Chakravarti, 1993). The surveillance that made the participants watch themselves in their academics, lest they be labeled loose, carries with it the privilege of belonging to the upper caste and class, which allows them to have a future. Thus, all the participants reported feeling 'pressured' to perform well in their academics not only to maintain a 'morally appropriate' character, but also because it was expected of them as a female belonging to a higher caste and socioeconomic class. Megha also noted that despite her outspoken attitude which would have otherwise afforded her harsher punishment, she was let off by the teachers on several instances of 'inappropriate' behavior because she belonged to the highest caste (Brahmin) within the structure of castes in Indian society. Additionally, the knowledge of her mother being an experienced teacher in the same school ameliorated the degree of punishment she faced for transgressing norms of appropriate feminine behavior. Amita experienced something similar, because of the knowledge that she belonged to the Brahmin caste, and the fact that her mother was a respected government official, she was often treated with leniency when her classmates were not.

5. Negotiation of self-expression

   Amita noted that the only way she could express her authentic self (joke with her friends, laugh loudly) was by being good in academics, because that lessened the punishment she would otherwise receive for breaking the rules of proper feminine behavior in school.

According to Yogita, "girls had to be academically great to be able to do even the smallest kind of self expression." This included expression of self through appearance (having different hairstyles, wearing some kind of light makeup, or altering the school uniform in any manner), or expressing your disapproval, or discontent with the authorities. Interestingly, for Megha, the norm of uniform became the currency with which she negotiated her self-expression. She always made sure that her uniform was tidy and her hair neatly braided so that when she would verbally call out her teachers' emotional abuse towards her (which she did often), they could not call into question her propriety in terms of appearance.

6. Inclusion and exclusion from opportunities of growth

   Amita noted that in her all-girls school, if you transgressed norms of proper feminine behavior, you were not just called incapable in academics, but specifically incapable of challenging academic subjects such as advanced math or science. She noted that her teachers would often deem students unfit for careers in STEM such as engineers or doctors, when they displayed errant behavior according to the teachers. Yogita's experience also elucidates the relationship between a student's perceived character, and the opportunities of growth allowed to her. She noted how she was once found walking the school corridor with her boyfriend when she was in 8th grade, and then lectured on morality and appropriate behavior. The following year, she was demoted to the position of 'prefect,' even though she was eligible to become a 'captain.' On this incident, she said "I knew that I was not made captain because I was 'caught' with a boy in the corridor. I was never given a reason why. But I just know it." In Yogita's school, the teachers decided who among a class of students were to be given the forms for applying to the prefectorial board in the first place. Those students who did not adhere to the norms of proper feminine behavior and whom the teachers considered of questionable character were not even given the opportunity to apply to positions of leadership, nevermind their abilities, skills, or goals.

7. Culture and Religion used to reinforce ideas of Curriculum of the Body

   Himani noted that there was a strong influence of the South Indian culture of propriety and chastity on the way she and her female classmates were expected to conduct themselves. Amita noted that in her convent school, the administration would frequently invoke the phrase "God is watching" when reinforcing norms of proper behavior. She noted that her school reinforced extremely strict rules of dress and behavior because it was a Christian school.

8. Heternormative school cultures reinforcing Curriculum of the Body

   There was a palpable male gaze within the co-ed schools, which functioned as a mechanism of surveillance. Himani's school culture reinforced the idea of "boys are always looking and therefore you must conduct yourself with grace." Also in her school, the narrative constructed for girls experimenting with appearances was not just "she is dressing up," but "she is dressing up for boys." Partially as a result of this narrative, the boys would comment on the so-called appropriate or inappropriate behavior of the girls,

deeming them 'good enough' for themselves (Sur, 2021). The boys passed judgments on their female classmates' characters, and were not stopped from doing so by the teachers or other authorities. Therefore, these heteronormative systems were reinforced by the lack of action on the part of authorities from stopping this behavior. The teachers too, engaged in teasing and associating male and female students with one another romantically within classes, thus reinforcing a heteronormative culture.

Another way that heteronormativity was reinforced in schools was through the infantilization of the female student. In Amita's girls-school, the parents were called for the smallest of trouble that students got into, reinforcing the ideas that the female is incapable of correcting her own self, and her caretakers to whom she "belongs" must be informed of every small and big aberration in her behavior.

Yogita mentioned how in her school, the girls barely ever transgressed the rules of proper behavior, in that, they never got into serious trouble that would invite serious punishment. However, the boys got into trouble often, and would be reprimanded by the teachers, coordinators, vice principal, and other authorities, At the same time, she expressed that her school displayed "no discrimination" between female and male students. This is contradictory, because the female students never getting into trouble is evidence of the discrimination that is characteristic of a heteronormative school culture.

In Amita's school, the culture of violence and punishment made evident the "ideal" female student. She had to be thin, fair, submissive, and good in academics. She explained this expectation through the story of her friend who was dark, outspoken, and built stoutly: all these characteristics of hers invited stronger surveillance and control over her actions, as well as harsher punishment. A similar control and surveillance over body was experienced by Megha, who recounted how her teacher remarked that she had "developed in the right places" when she was in 9th grade and went through puberty.

Heteronormativity was also reinforced through the duties and responsibilities that were assigned typically to a female student. Yogita noted how duties such as welcoming the chief guests during special assemblies, and putting up decorations were specifically assigned to female students, because they were perceived to be more 'feminine' duties.

The point of this discussion is that heteronormative discourses shaped and reinforced the dictates of 'proper' or Brahmanical femininity (Chakravarti, 1993) in all of the participants' schools, which further led to the control of their bodies, and their learning experiences (Lesko, 1988).

Conclusion

The impact of the Curriculum of the Body on the participants was layered and complex. Firstly, it led to the creation of social hierarchies (Lesko, 1988). Megha remarked how, due to her being labeled as problematic and characterless because of her outspoken nature, she did not have friends in school; her rule-abiding and less vocal classmates did not interact with her. Yogita remembered staying within a close-knit group of friends who were all academically high-performing students, and being unable to remember the personal experiences of other students who were victims of character assassination. Similarly, Himani mentioned how she "did not know any of those girls" when asked to recall the experiences of her peers who experienced character assassination. Their lack of knowledge of the 'other' category of female students signifies the very existence of social hierarchies within female students, of which they belonged to the higher kind. Also, a sense of competition with other women was learnt as a result of the

social hierarchies. Amita reflected how she was implicitly encouraged to do 'better' than the girls who were labelled as 'characterless' or 'not smart,' as opposed to collaborating with them.

The impact on self-image was palpable. Amita notes that she has internalized a policing voice that tells her to "not make noise" at all times, which translates into her silencing herself in crucial moments, and feeling difficulty in expressing herself. Both Amita and Yogita mentioned an internalized lack of confidence. Additionally, they both describe feeling "constricted" as a result of being policed in school. Amita expressed, "a school is supposed to be the place you have fun, you laugh, you run, you express yourself, because all of that is anyway not allowed, or is controlled in Indian families. But I felt controlled even in school, and I resent my school and teachers for it". Meanwhile, Yogita stated how she cannot shake off the constant feeling of being watched, and therefore, conducts herself with a stifling vigilance at all times, thus evidencing how she has deeply internalized the surveillance.

As a result of the Curriculum of the Body, the participants lived inauthentic lives as students in schools. Yogita expressed disappointment because she apologized for being seen with a male classmate even when she did not want to. Megha noted how she had to constantly live in defense-mode because she was labeled an insincere and 'loose' student, as opposed to being understood and being carefree, as a child should. Yogita and Himani too, expressed how they would have taken risks, tried different things like relationships or going out with friends, had it not been for the label of promiscuity associated with both of those activities.

Discussion and Recommendations

The data collected from the interviews points towards a culture of surveillance, violence, and dehumanization that exists in schools. This insidious culture creates inauthentic learning experiences for the female students, who grow up with perceptions of self that are informed by complex traumas and being labled (Lesko, 1988). It is evident that the teachers reinforce these norms within a larger ecosystem of surveillance and discipline. Therefore, it is recommended that a series of suggestions and recommendations for teachers that sensitizes them about Curriculum of the Body, would encourage them to reflect on their own experiences of oppression as women, and female students, their pedagogies, the impact of this culture on their students, the teachers' own purposes of becoming an educator, as well as systems of patriarchy embedded within schools. These must allow for sensitization through reflective activities, holding space, and coming to terms with their own traumas and center conversations that destigmatize sex, relationships, and ideas of morality ascribed to the female-gender performance (Sur, 2021). They should be adaptive to specific school and cultural contexts, especially in a diverse country like India. Furthermore, it is recommended that conversations would be coupled with real-time experiences and activities that improve teachers' exposure to the world that helps them broaden their outlook on society and gender. Ultimately, the goal is to awaken the critical consciousness of the teachers in a way that not only compels them to rethink the power asymmetries in their classroom and their pedagogies, but also makes them conscious of their own oppression within their households and society, so that it creates a disruption within systems of patriarchy (Freire, 1970). The training curriculum will take the form of sustained professional development.

Reflections

This is a formative study of a phenomenon that is worth exploring, examining, and institutionalizing or formalizing within teacher education curricula. I have a hunch that this is not

covered in teacher education curricula in India in the way that it exists right now. I envision such a curriculum having vignettes—personal accounts of female students being surveilled and dehumanized—that serve as tools of reflection for the teachers through which they feel seen and heard, and are able to reflect about their own experiences and pedagogy that might be inflicting this violence on the female students. These reflections can inform their practice. Furthermore, there are several directions that this study can take in the future: it can be used to examine and restructure teacher education systems, it can be used to examine and redefine school cultures, and institutionalized patriarchy/sexism. It can also be used to examine the caste-class-gender dynamics and intersectionalities within classroom and school spaces. What I mean is that this study is the creation and examination of several ideas that are worth exploring to address bigger issues of patriarchy that influence female students' experiences of learning and self identity within schools in that it seriously affects normative measures of success like staying in school, feeling belonged, feeling confident, and being ambitious in female students.

Limitations of the study

Absence of diverse perspectives: only cisgender heterosexual females were interviewed, who belonged to dominant upper castes. This can be made more complex if "female student" is defined to encompass multiple intersecting identities in the study, and effort is made to document the diverse learning experiences of more female students who fall within the broader definition. Further, the study can be made more holistic by gathering teacher perspectives, investigating their purposes behind enforcement of Curriculum of the Body, and their own negotiations with it as a teacher, and a woman.

References

Arya, S. (2020). Dalit or Brahmanical Patriarchy? Rethinking Indian Feminism. CASTE: A Global Journal on Social Exclusion, 1(1), 217–228. https://www.jstor.org/stable/48644572

Ball, S.J. (Ed.). (1990). Foucault and Education: Disciplines and Knowledge (1st ed.). Routledge. https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203092781

Chakravarti, U. "Men, Women and the Embattled Family", in Uma Chakravarti, Rewriting History: The Life and Times of Pandita Ramabai. New Delhi: Zubaan Books, 2013, pp. 200-246. Reproduced with permission from Zubaan Publishers Private Ltd, New Delhi. © author.

Cook-Sather, Alison. "Authorizing Students' Perspectives: Toward Trust, Dialogue, and Change in Education." Educational Researcher 31, no. 4 (2002): 3–14. http://www.jstor.org/stable/3594363.

Sonu, D. (2022). Making a racial difference: a Foucauldian analysis of school memories told by undergraduates of color in the United States. *Critical Studies in Education*, *63*(3), 340–354. https://doi-org.tc.idm.oclc.org/10.1080/17508487.2020.1763415

Foucault, M. (1979). Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison: 2: The Means of Correct Training. Vintage Books.

Geetha, V. "Masculinity and Femininity: Ideas are Real", Reproduced from V. Geetha.2002, in Gender, Stree, pp. 39-49. © 2015 V. Geetha.

Kītā, V. (2007b). *Patriarchy*.

Knight, M. & Marciano, J. (2019). Classroom cultures: Equitable schooling for racially diverse youth, Building Productive Teacher-Student Relationships. New York: Teachers College Press.

Krishnan, K. (2018). Gendered discipline in globalising India. Feminist Review, 119, 72–88. https://www.jstor.org/stable/26776502.

Lesko, N. (1988). The curriculum of the body: Lessons from a Catholic high school. In L. Roman, L. K. Christian-Smith, & E. Ellsworth (Eds.), Becoming feminine: The politics of popular culture (pp. 123–142). London, UK: Falmer.

Macey, D., & Foucault, M. (2003). Society must be defended. Picador.

Nevatia, S., Raj, Mahajan, S. and Shah, C."Bound by Norms and Out of Bounds: Experiences of PAGFB (Persons Assigned Gender Female at Birth) Within the Formal Education System". Originally published in Contemporary Education Dialogue, Vol. 9, No. 2, pp. 173-196. Copyright © 2012 Education Dialogue Trust, Delhi. All rights reserved. Reproduced with the permission of the copyright holders and the publishers, Sage Publications India Pvt. Ltd., New Delhi.

Paik, S. "Chhadi Lage Chham Chham, Vidya Yegi Gham Gham (The harder the stick beats, the faster the flow of knowledge): Dalit Women's Struggle for Education". Indian Journal of Gender Studies, Vol. 16, No. 2, pp. 175-204. Copyright 2009 © Centre for Women's Development Studies, New Delhi. All rights reserved. Reproduced with the permission of the copyright holder and the publishers, Sage Publications India Pvt. Ltd., New Delhi.

Saldaña, J. (2009). The Coding Manual for Qualitative Researchers. http://ci.nii.ac.jp/ncid/BB20067005

Sur, Piyali (2021). Discipline and Surveillance: Adolescent Girls talk about Body and Sexuality: A Case Study from Kolkata, India. Journal of International Women's Studies, 22(1), 401-416. Available at: https://vc.bridgew.edu/jiws/vol22/iss1/24

Takacs, D. (2002). Positionality, Epistemology, and Social Justice in the Classroom. Social Justice, 29(4 (90)), 168–181. http://www.jstor.org/stable/29768156